

Oh, Build Me A Home...

If you're an expert with 3D design and architectural drawing tools, go away—this *Fast Track* isn't for you, and neither is SketchUp. You'll be happier with tools like AutoCAD and 3ds Max.

Really now, shoo.

If you must stay, however, know this—while SketchUp isn't as evolved as the aforementioned tools, it's far from a beginner's toy. It combines shocking levels of usability with even more shocking levels of functionality, and has, in fact, been designed so that even eighth-graders have no trouble with it (so if you're still not comfortable with it after this *Fast Track*, shame on you).

So if SketchUp's so simple and user-friendly, why this *Fast Track*? Couldn't you just install the software, fire it up and get going? In truth, yes. SketchUp even gives first timers a helpful guide the first time you run it. What we're doing here, however, is showing you what SketchUp's really capable of—functionality that you won't see if you're just playing around.

We've approached this book in the way that many of you might—with no prior knowledge of SketchUp or 3D modelling concepts in general. There are no assumptions on expertise (besides that you're handy with a keyboard and mouse), so if you find us getting too basic, this is deliberate, and we'll forgive you for skipping ahead.

Every 3D modelling tool has its forte—some are great for organic models, some for special effects, and so on. So what do you do with SketchUp? If you take a trip through the online 3D Warehouse, you'll see that a majority of the community is making buildings—we've assumed that you'll be doing so too, and that's how things will progress in this book.

Google has designed SketchUp primarily to help even ordinary people model buildings with varying complexity (not that you can't do other stuff, mind you). These buildings can then be put into Google Earth, and hopefully, we'll see all the world's cities in 3D some day. It's a massive crowdsourcing operation by the big G—some might even call it a huge *Matrix*-like human farm—but heck, we're all doing it anyway. Enough